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Adaptive by Design

An AI strategy for secondary schools that begins with inclusion: what the 2025–26 guidance asks of leaders, and a tested way to meet it

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What this document is

It is written for headteachers, senior teams, governors and trust boards who must now set a position on artificial intelligence (AI) in school. It reads the guidance published between October 2025 and September 2026, names the gap between what schools are now asked to do and what most are able to do, and sets out one way to close it, tested in a London comprehensive.

Its argument is simple. **The guidance asks schools to judge AI by its effect on pupils, and to show that pupils who face barriers are reached.** An AI strategy that starts anywhere other than inclusion will be measured against a question it was not built to answer.

Harlington School appears throughout as the worked case study. Its material is used because it exists and can be inspected, not because the approach depends on it. The figures are given as they stand in October 2026; where a claim has not yet been tested, this document says so.

SUMMARY OF RECOMMENDATIONS

Seven decisions are needed. The first three set the direction; the last four make it safe, sustainable and honest. Each is developed in the section shown in brackets.

1 **Write the AI strategy as part of the inclusion strategy, not beside it**
Ofsted now grades inclusion as its own evaluation area and judges AI only by its impact on pupils. The 2026 white paper asks every school for an annual inclusion strategy. One document, one set of measures, one owner. [§03]

2 **Use AI where the evidence on adaptive teaching is strongest**
Pre-teaching, scaffolds that fade, and retrieval practice, with every pupil working towards the same task. This follows the EEF's guidance on SEND in mainstream schools and the SENSE study's warning that differentiation too often becomes lowered demand. [§03]

3	**Draw the boundary before the permissions** Name where AI is not used: judging pupils, predicted grades, pupil reports, deciding whether a pupil has SEN, the content of an EHCP, emotional or mental-health support. The DfE's 2026 support materials draw the same line for SEND. [§05]
4	**Tier oversight by consequence, not by tool** Specialist sign-off for anything asserting what an examiner rewards; subject-lead review for taught content; sampled checks for revision material derived from it. Name the tiers, the signatories and the record. [§05]
5	**Keep pupil data out by design, and put AI inside safeguarding** Public pages hold no accounts and no pupil data. Any pupil-facing tool is checked against the DfE's generative AI product safety standards, and AI is in scope of the annual filtering and monitoring review that KCSIE 2026 requires. [§05]
6	**Build once, centrally, and put the time in a role** Teachers using AI save time that is absorbed elsewhere, and four in ten have had no training. Start low on the risk slope and climb in order. Decide in advance where the time AI frees will go. Departments supply curriculum thinking; one team builds to one standard; staff are trained in the practice, not the tool. [§06]
7	**Agree the evaluation before the rollout** Set the baseline first, and include measures that can return bad news, among them signs of cognitive offloading. Report what did not work to governors alongside what did. [§07]

01 WHAT CHANGED IN TWELVE MONTHS

Between October 2025 and September 2026 the rules for AI in English schools moved from permission to expectation. None of the documents below tells a school to use AI. Taken together, they tell a school how its use of AI will be judged, and the answer is the same each time: by what it does for pupils, especially those who find learning hardest to reach.

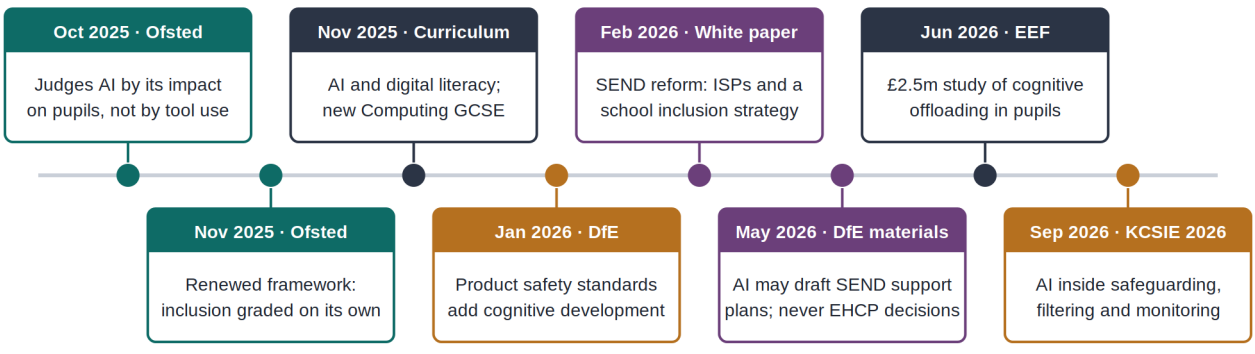


Figure 1. Eight publications in twelve months. Teal: inspection; plum: SEND and inclusion; amber: safety; slate: curriculum and research.

Inspection judges impact, and grades inclusion on its own

Ofsted's guidance on AI, revised on 21 October 2025, states that inspectors will not evaluate AI use as such and do not expect schools to use any particular tool. They look at the effect of AI on pupils' education, and at whether risks to data, bias and safeguarding are managed. Ofsted is candid that there is not yet enough evidence to say what good AI use looks like.

From 10 November 2025 the renewed inspection framework reports on a five-point scale and makes **inclusion** a separate evaluation area. Inspectors ask how a school identifies and supports pupils with special educational needs and disabilities (SEND), disadvantaged pupils and children known to social care. In practice that is the familiar question a head of department asks on a learning walk, put to the whole school: *is this lesson reaching the pupil in the corner who is not putting a hand up?*

SEND reform gives the strategy its structure

The February 2026 schools white paper replaces much of the current SEND system with layers of support. Most pupils' needs are met through a **universal offer**: the teaching and adjustments every pupil can expect. Pupils who need more receive an **individual support plan (ISP)**, written by the school. Education, health and care plans (EHCPs) are kept for specialist provision. Each school will publish an annual **inclusion strategy** in place of the SEN information report. Most of this lands from 2029, but the schools that have already written down their universal offer will find the change an update rather than a rebuild.

In May 2026 the DfE's support materials on using AI, developed with Chiltern Learning Trust and the Chartered College of Teaching, were updated to say that AI may help draft initial support plans and staff guides, with great care over sensitive information. They are equally clear about what AI must not do: write statutory documents such as EHCPs without full professional review, decide whether a pupil has SEN, or provide emotional or mental-health support (as reported by Schools Week, 28 May 2026).

Safety moves inside safeguarding

The DfE's generative AI product safety standards, first published in January 2025, were extended on 19 January 2026 with new standards on pupils' **cognitive development**, **emotional and social development**, **mental health** and **manipulation**. They are the checklist a school should hold any pupil-facing tool against.

Keeping children safe in education 2026, in force from 1 September 2026, brings AI into safeguarding: images generated by AI, including so-called deepfakes, are treated as safeguarding matters; harmful interactions with generative AI applications, such as chatbots, are listed among contact risks; and AI is in scope of the annual review of filtering and monitoring led by a senior leader with the designated safeguarding lead. (Summarised from published secondary analyses; paragraph references should be checked against the statutory text before they are quoted.)

The research is catching up, and it is asking the right question

In June 2026 the Education Endowment Foundation (EEF) opened a £2.5 million fund to study **cognitive offloading**: whether pupils hand the work of remembering and reasoning to AI, and what that does to learning. First findings are expected in 2027. Teachers will recognise the problem from homework: a correct answer the pupil cannot explain. Any strategy written now should be designed so that it does not depend on the answer coming out well.

02 THE GAP BETWEEN THE RULES AND THE SCHOOLS

The guidance assumes that schools have someone who can turn principles into practice. The survey evidence says most do not.

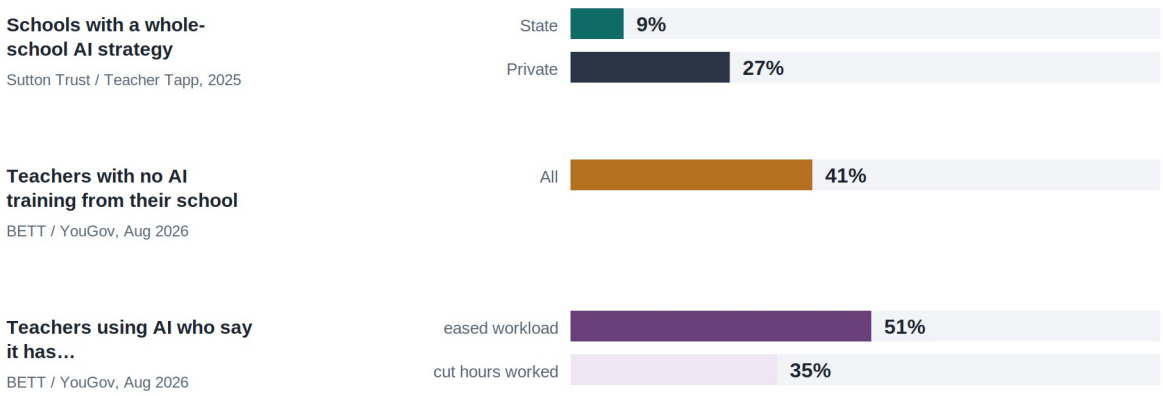


Figure 2. Three findings. Sources: Sutton Trust / Teacher Tapp (April 2025 fieldwork); BETT / YouGov survey of 1,033 teachers (Schools Week, 27 August 2026).

Only 9% of state school teachers reported a school-wide AI strategy, against 27% in private schools, and teachers in more affluent state schools were more likely to have been trained than those in less affluent ones (26% against 18%). A year later, 41% of teachers said they had received no training or support at all. Among teachers using AI, 51% said it had eased their workload, but only 35% were working fewer hours: the time saved is absorbed elsewhere.

Leaders know this. In September 2026 the National Institute of Teaching reported leaders responding to AI guidance with the same question: what do I actually do? A report by Sir Anthony Seldon and Tim Bunting (22 September 2026) goes further, proposing governor-approved AI strategies in every school and inspection of them. That is a proposal, not policy. It does show where the debate is heading.

The same pattern appears outside education. McKinsey's survey work for its October 2026 article *AI is changing work. Now it has to change the organization* finds that 80% of respondents say AI has made them more productive, but only 37% report a measurable gain for their organisation as a whole. Seventy per cent feel personally ready for AI; only 27% of leaders say their organisation is. The study is of companies, not schools, and its figures should not be read across as if they were. Its conclusion transfers well, though: **individual tools raise individual productivity; only changing how the work itself is organised changes the result.** In a school, the work is the curriculum and how it is taught.

Why the gap is an inclusion problem

When AI arrives without a strategy, its benefits flow to the pupils and staff already best placed to use it: those with devices at home, confident readers, teachers with time to experiment. The Sutton Trust and ASCL warn that AI could widen attainment gaps unless it is deliberately used to close them. A strategy that starts from inclusion is the deliberate version.

03 THE ARGUMENT: AN AI STRATEGY IS AN INCLUSION STRATEGY

Most AI strategies begin with tools: which assistant staff may use, which sites are blocked. This one begins with a classroom problem every teacher knows. A class of thirty contains pupils who arrive without the words the lesson will use, pupils who can do the task with one step shown, and pupils who need no help at all. Good teachers already adapt for all three. The difficulty is doing it every lesson, in every subject, without lowering what is expected of anyone.

What the research says adaptive teaching should look like

The EEF's guidance on SEND in mainstream schools recommends a small set of approaches, often called the 'five-a-day': **explicit instruction**, **cognitive and metacognitive strategies**, **scaffolding**, **flexible grouping** and **using technology** to support them. Its central message is that high-quality teaching for pupils with SEND is high-quality teaching, made more deliberate.

The SENSE study (Webster and Blatchford), drawing on more than a thousand hours of classroom observation, shows what happens when that principle is stated but not organised: pupils with EHCPs spend more time away from the class teacher, adaptation is improvised by support staff, and differentiation turns into easier work. Its lesson for leaders is that support must add to the teacher's work with the pupil, never replace it.

Retrieval practice adds the third strand. The EEF's review of cognitive science finds the evidence for low-stakes quizzing 'moderate and generally positive', with the caution that few studies were run by ordinary class teachers. It matters here for one reason: a pupil who has to recall before being helped is doing the thinking that cognitive offloading would take away.

The model: four steps with one destination

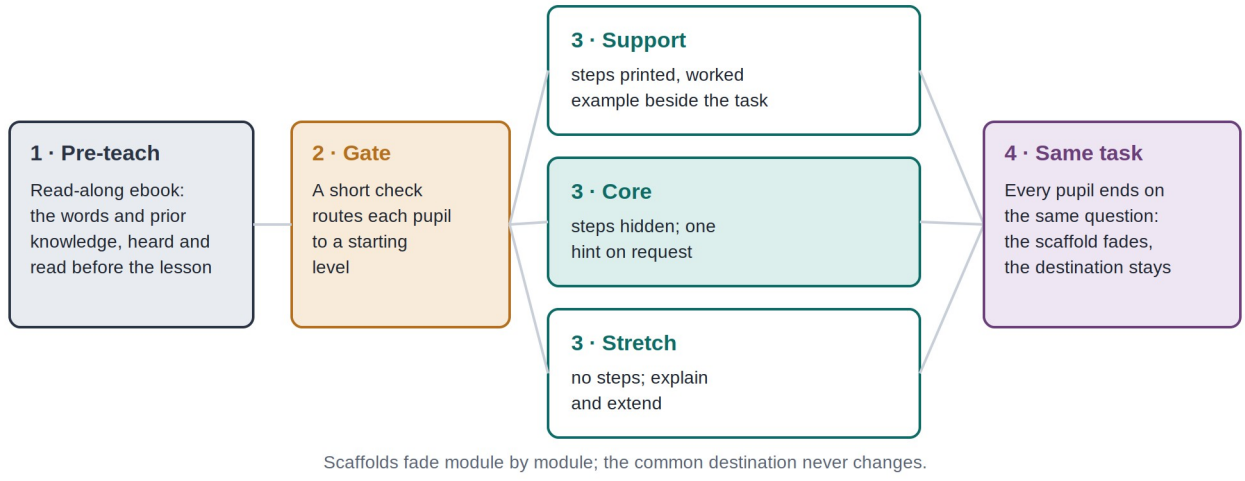


Figure 3. The adaptive model used in the Harlington pages. The level changes how much help is visible, never the question.

1. **Pre-teach.** Before the lesson, the pupil hears and reads the words and prior knowledge it will rely on, in a read-along ebook where the text is highlighted as the audio plays. This is the low-literacy pupil's way in.
2. **Gate.** A short check, two or three questions, places the pupil at a starting level. Recall comes before any help is shown.

3. **Three levels of scaffold.** *Support* prints the steps and a worked example beside the task; *Core* hides the steps behind one hint; *Stretch* removes them and asks the pupil to explain and extend.
4. **One destination.** Every pupil finishes on the same question. As modules progress the scaffold fades, so that support is a route in, never a lower ceiling.

> **On a Tuesday, in a Year 8 science lesson**
>
> A class will meet series circuits on Thursday. On Tuesday, four pupils identified by the department's pre-assessment, not by the SEND register, open the read-along chapter: the components, the symbols, the word *current* used in a sentence each. On Thursday they start the lesson holding the vocabulary the explanation stands on, and the teacher checks their understanding first. If two terms of exit tickets show no difference, the evaluation will say so.
>
> This is the pre-teaching action from the author's proposal for leading SEND at Harlington, and the reason Electric Circuits is one of the five exemplar units built in October 2026.

Where AI does the work, and where people do

AI makes this model affordable. Writing a unit three times over at three levels of scaffold, with an audio script and a gate, is what makes adaptive teaching hard to sustain by hand. AI drafts it from the department's own lesson decks; a subject specialist checks and signs it. Decisions about individual pupils stay with people.

04 CASE STUDY: HARLINGTON SCHOOL, 2025–26

Harlington is an 11–18 comprehensive in the London Borough of Hillingdon with a specialist resource provision and a designated unit for autistic pupils. The work below was built by one head of department, largely in school holidays and outside the duties of the post. It is offered as evidence that the model can be built and run, not as evidence that it raises attainment, which has not yet been tested.

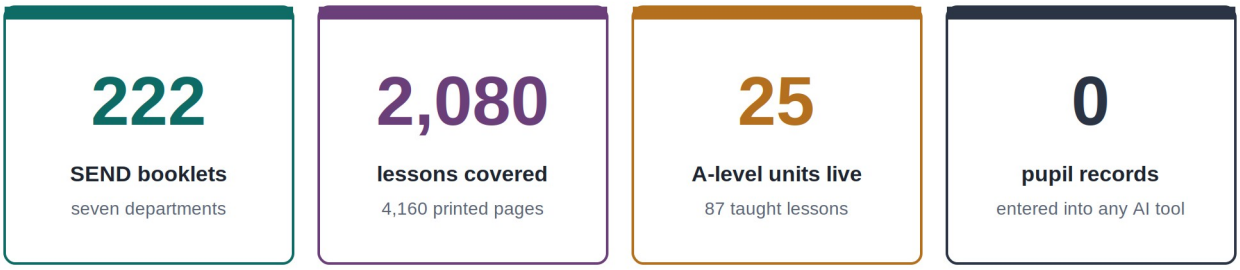


Figure 4. The case in numbers, October 2026. Counts are taken from each department's manifest.

What was built

- **A complete A-level course portal.** Twenty-five units of Philosophy, Ethics and Christianity, eighty-seven taught lessons, reached from one address on any device without a login. Lesson decks, booklets, a philosopher companion, flashcards, podcast episodes and exam-question organisers sit behind each unit.
- **SEND booklets across seven departments.** 222 booklets covering 2,080 lessons in English, Maths, Science, Geography, History, French and Spanish, built from each department's own lesson decks. Every booklet gives two pages per lesson in black and white, and gives structure only where

the slide sets a task. Nothing appears that is not on the board. Each is delivered as a Word file for printing and a PowerPoint file for the department to amend.

- **Read-along ebooks.** Low-literacy pupils hear the text while each sentence is highlighted, using the device's own voice. A Year 8 English unit has editions with instructions in Arabic, Urdu and Ukrainian; their translations have not yet been checked by speakers and are not yet in use with pupils.
- **Core-subject exemplars (in build, October 2026).** One unit each in English Language, English Literature, Maths, Combined Science and Triple Science, built on the four-step model in Figure 3, for specialist review before any wider use.

How it is put together

The design separates what may be public from what may not. That separation is what lets the copyright, data-protection and ownership questions each have an answer before they are asked.

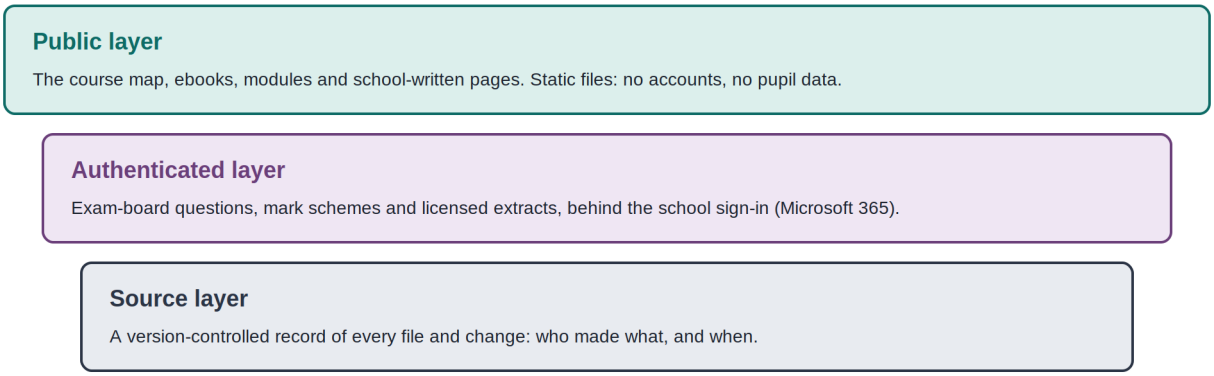


Figure 5. The three layers. Exam-board material never sits on the public layer.

Each course is described in a single file (a **manifest**): its years, strands, units and the big question each unit answers. The pages build themselves from it. Changing the file changes the subject. This has been tested rather than assumed: the same portal has been run as a History site without a line of its code changing. What a department supplies is curriculum thinking, typically a morning's work for a head of department; the build is done centrally.

What it claims, and what it does not

Claim	Status in October 2026
Material for a whole course can be found in under a minute, on a phone	Designed for; to be measured with Year 12 and 13 classes
Booklets reproduce only what the department's slides set	Checked mechanically against each deck's text; languages checked string by string
The adaptive pages improve learning for pupils with SEND	Not yet tested. Pilot evaluation planned against a baseline
No pupil data enters any AI tool	Holds by design: AI drafts from anonymised context sheets and department decks only
Translated EAL editions are accurate	Not yet checked by speakers; not in use with pupils

An audit of the A-level pages in August 2026 found some carrying past-paper wording, which exam-board terms do not allow on a public site. A checking tool now runs before publication, and correcting the affected pages is the first action in any implementation plan. It is recorded here because a strategy that only reports its successes cannot be trusted with its claims.

05 GOVERNANCE: THE BOUNDARY, THE TIERS AND THE SAFEGUARDS

Most material in an ecosystem like this is drafted with AI and edited by a subject specialist. A school needs a position on that whether or not it adopts this model, and a vague one will either block everything or permit everything.

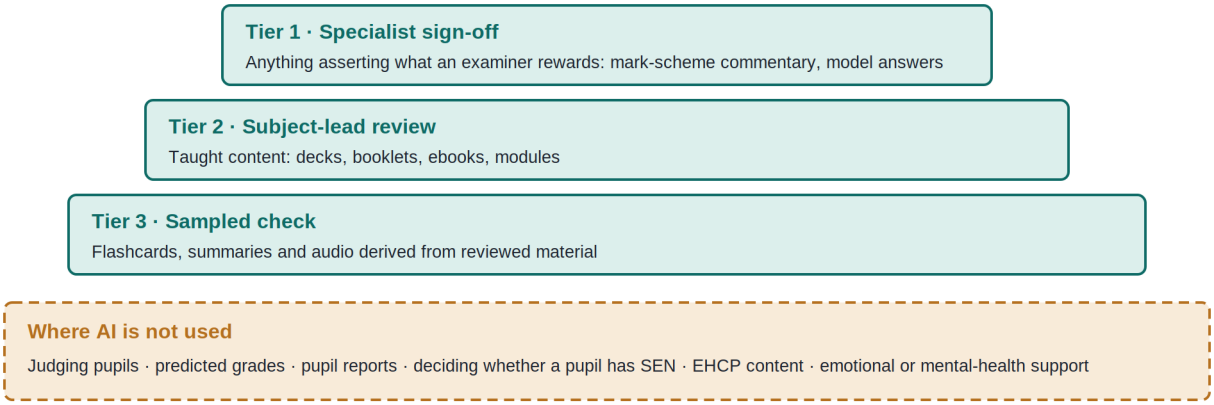


Figure 6. Oversight follows the consequence of the material, and a fixed boundary sits beneath it.

Draw the boundary first

A policy that lists only what is permitted is not a position. This one starts with what AI is not used for: making assessment judgements about pupils, producing predicted grades, writing reports on individual pupils, deciding whether a pupil has SEN, writing the content of an EHCP, or offering emotional or mental-health support. Every item on that list matches either the DfE's 2026 support materials or data-protection law. Naming the boundary, and keeping it, is what makes the permitted uses defensible to parents, governors and inspectors.

Tier oversight by consequence

A rule that every AI-assisted page must be checked line by line does not survive contact with two thousand lessons. A tiered rule does. Anything that tells pupils what an examiner rewards is signed off by a second subject specialist. Taught content is reviewed by the subject lead before pupils see it. Revision material derived from reviewed content is sampled against its source. For each tier the school names who signs and keeps a record that they did.

Safeguards, in the terms the guidance uses

Area	The position	Source
Pupil data	Public pages have no accounts, analytics, forms or pupil identifiers. AI drafts from anonymised context sheets that list needs and strategies, never names. Any change goes to the data protection officer first.	DfE generative AI guidance; ICO Children's code

Area	The position	Source
Pupil-facing tools	Checked against the product safety standards before use, including the January 2026 standards on cognitive and emotional development, mental health and manipulation.	DfE product safety standards (Jan 2026)
Safeguarding	AI in scope of the annual filtering and monitoring review; AI-generated images handled as safeguarding concerns; chatbots treated as a contact risk.	KCSIE 2026
Copyright	Exam-board questions, mark schemes and licensed extracts kept behind the school sign-in. Pupils' work never used to train AI.	AQA Copyright Policy for Centres; CLA Licence; DfE guidance
Accessibility	Built to WCAG 2.2 AA as school policy, with an accessibility statement. The Equality Act duty to make reasonable adjustments applies regardless.	Equality Act 2010; DfE digital accessibility standard
Assessment	No reliance on AI-detection tools, which are unreliable and can disadvantage pupils with English as an additional language.	DfE support materials (2026), as reported; JCQ

06 IMPLEMENTATION: BUILD ONCE, TRAIN FOR PRACTICE

The EEF's guidance on implementation is blunt: most new approaches fail in the doing, not the choosing. Its four phases (explore, prepare, deliver, sustain) frame the plan below. Most of the effort sits in changing what teachers do with the material, rather than in building it.

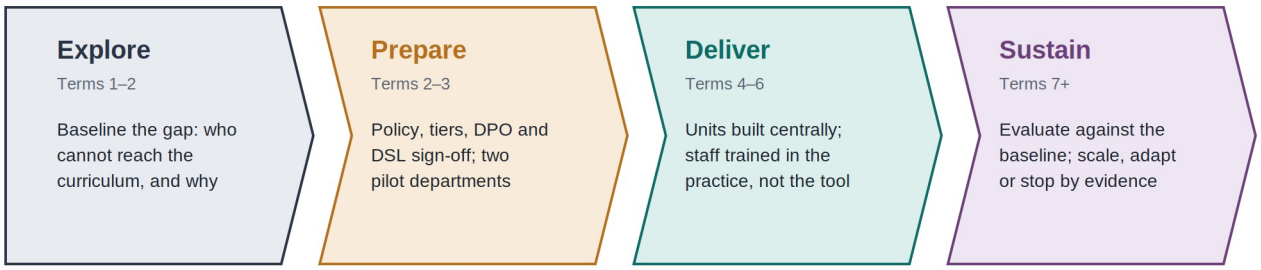


Figure 7. Phases follow the EEF's implementation guidance; term numbers are indicative.

Climb the risk slope

Webster and Westerman's study of 21 large companies for *MIT Sloan Management Review* found that the organisations getting real value from generative AI were not attempting one large transformation. They were making smaller, deliberate changes, ordered by risk: first the everyday tasks that many staff share, then specialist work in which a person reviews everything the AI produces, and only then anything that faces the customer directly. Each step builds the capability, the trust and the data that make the next one safer. In a school the customer is the pupil, so the order matters more.

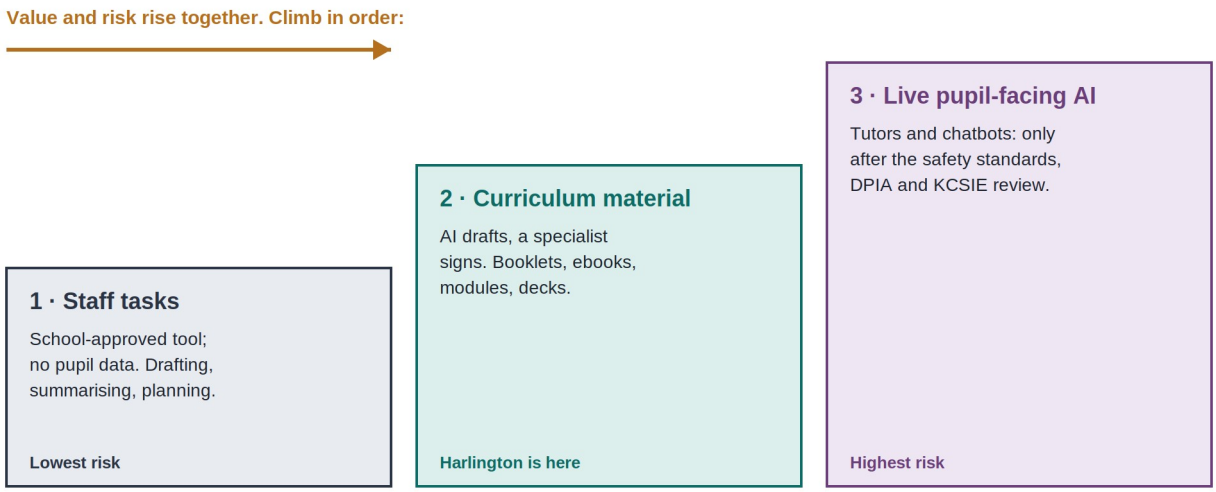


Figure 8. The risk slope for schools, after Webster and Westerman (2025). The DfE makes the same distinction: teacher-facing uses carry fewer risks than pupil-facing ones.

Harlington sits on the second step, and the distinction is worth stating plainly. Pupils meet material that AI drafted and a subject specialist checked; they do not talk to an AI. Live pupil-facing tools such as AI tutors and chatbots belong on the third step: they are worth considering, and the DfE's own tutoring tools are due in schools by the end of 2027, but only after the product safety standards check, a data protection impact assessment (DPIA) and the KCSIE filtering review. The same study warns that moving from a successful pilot to use across a whole organisation is the hard part, because trust has to be built with many more people. One leader it quotes put the task for leaders in a phrase any teacher will recognise: *"Build the scaffolding to bring everybody along."*

Why centrally

A single department's success is, in most organisations, the kind of thing that does not spread. What spreads is a shared platform: one architecture, one set of templates, one review workflow and one standard. Departments therefore supply the curriculum thinking and check the content; the build is done once. That also keeps the workload where it belongs. The DfE's workload guidance lists maintaining virtual learning environments among tasks teachers should not routinely be asked to do, and the survey evidence shows AI time savings absorbed rather than returned. The answer is not to spread the task across a department but to place it in a role with the hours in it.

McKinsey's research points the same way from outside education: among the organisations that gain most from AI, nearly three-quarters have substantially redesigned how work is done, against about a quarter of the rest. It also argues for one senior leader with real authority over the change, and for building for everyday use rather than for pilots. For a school this means one member of the senior team who holds the strategy, and units built to be taught with from the first week.

Decide where the saved time goes

Time freed by AI is not a saving until someone decides how it is spent; otherwise, as the teacher surveys show, other work fills it. The strategy names the destination in advance, and names it in terms of pupils: the hours a department saves in adapting resources go to pre-teaching groups, to feedback on extended writing, and to the termly review of pupils on SEN Support. Governors can then ask a precise question at the end of the year: where did the time go?

Protect the routes into expertise

McKinsey warns that where AI takes over entry-level work, organisations must build new routes by which people gain expertise. Schools face this directly. Planning a lesson, writing a scaffold and adapting a task for a pupil are how early-career teachers learn their craft. If AI drafts every resource, new teachers lose the practice that makes them expert. There is a second side to this. A study of AI support for customer-service staff, reported by Webster and Westerman, found productivity rose by 14% on average but by 34% for the newest and least experienced staff: the tool spread the practice of the best workers to the rest. The setting is not a school, but the lesson carries over. Used well, AI can model expert practice for novices; used carelessly, it removes the practice through which they would have become expert. In this strategy, trainees and early-career teachers write their own adaptations first and then compare them with the AI draft, under a mentor. AI is the second draft for a novice and the first draft for an expert.

Train the practice, not the tool

Staff development follows the same order as the model. Teachers practise pre-teaching, gating and fading scaffolds with material from their own subject, observed by a colleague who has used them. Generic whole-staff sessions on ‘using AI’ are avoided: the Great Teaching Toolkit review (Coe et al., 2020) finds that generic training changes little for experienced teachers. Departments and teachers are trained at the stage they are at.

The first ninety days in a new school

1. Map where pupils with SEND, disadvantaged pupils and pupils with EAL lose access to the curriculum, using the school’s own data, before anything is built.
2. Agree the boundary and the three tiers with the headteacher, the SENCo, the designated safeguarding lead and the data protection officer, and record them as policy.
3. Add AI to the filtering and monitoring review, and check any pupil-facing tool against the product safety standards.
4. Choose two departments and one unit each, starting with the teachers already experimenting with AI, who become the department’s champions. Agree with them what success would look like by the summer.
5. Take the baseline (Section 07) while one can still be taken.
6. Build the two units on the four-step model, review them through the tiers, and teach with them.
7. Report to governors at the end of the term on what worked and what did not.

07 EVALUATION: MEASURES THAT CAN RETURN BAD NEWS

Use is not impact; a page can be busy and useless. The measures below are few, each is taken against a baseline, and two of them are designed to be able to embarrass the person proposing them. The DfE’s 2024–25 technology survey found that only 35% of school leaders had any way of telling whether their technology was effective. Without such measures, a year with no problems reported is a year with no honest evaluation.

Measure	How it is taken	Why it matters
Teacher attention	Sampled share of lesson time in which pupils with EHCPs are the focus of the class teacher, taken before and after (the SENSE measure).	Tests whether support adds to the teacher's work or replaces it
Pre-teaching effect	Exit-ticket results for pre-taught pupils against their peers, over two terms.	Scale or stop, by evidence
Common destination	Learning walks: do pupils at every level reach the same final task?	Catches lowered demand
Offloading check	Gate scores (recall before help) tracked over a unit; pupils explaining an answer aloud.	Can return bad news; watches for the risk the EEF is now studying
Staff time	Self-reported time spent finding or adapting resources, before rollout and in July.	Expected to rise first; can return bad news
Spread	Subjects live by July, and whether heads of department describe the pages as theirs.	Ownership, not compliance

08 COST, AND WHAT MAKES IT LAST

There is no software to buy. Public pages are static files on free hosting; the authenticated layer is the Microsoft 365 licence a school already holds; the source record is free. The real cost is leadership time: someone senior who holds the strategy, runs the review workflow and leads the change in teaching. Studies of public-sector technology programmes put the cost of changing practice at several times the cost of the technology; here the technology term is close to zero, which makes the leadership cost the whole cost.

Three arrangements make the work durable rather than personal. The school holds a deployable copy of its own pages, so availability never rests on an account it does not control. The terms on which the framework is used are written down. And the capability sits in a post with hours attached rather than in one person's holidays.

IN SUMMARY

- The 2025–26 guidance judges AI by its effect on pupils and grades inclusion separately. An AI strategy should start where it will be judged.
- The approach with the strongest evidence is adaptive teaching made deliberate: pre-teach, gate, scaffold, fade, same destination.
- AI makes that affordable at scale; people keep every decision about individual pupils.
- The boundary, the tiers and the safeguards each answer a question a governor, parent or inspector will ask.
- It has been built and run in one school, and its claims are qualified where the evidence is qualified.

What it needs is a senior post with the time in it, and an evaluation agreed before it starts.

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